

See also: The *Lex Aquilia* 34 ■ Gratian's *Decretum* 60–63 ■ Magna Carta 66–71 ■ The Venetian Patent Statute 82–85
■ The Treaty of Tordesillas 86–87 ■ The Statute of Anne 106–107

William of Normandy **conquers England** and **confiscates land** from the Anglo-Saxon aristocracy.

He **keeps one-sixth** of the land for himself and **distributes** the rest to **noble tenants-in-chief**, who **own land in return for services** to him.

The **Domesday Book commissioners** are sent out to **compile lists of the nobles' estates** and their values.

The results of the Domesday survey **provide a legal basis for land-holding** across the whole country.

absolutely. Furthermore, an individual could have acquired private property by occupying land with no recorded owner. William's new form of land-holding swept away these traditional rights.

Noble tenants-in-chief were now enfeoffed (given a fief, or land with its peasants and the income it provided) by the king on certain conditions—principally military service or rent. The new tenants-in-chief received something like legal title to their land for the first time; they in turn granted portions of their fiefs to subtenants.

No one save the king now held land in their own right and the former free men of the Anglo-Saxon period became tenants, including

some (known as villeins) who were tied to their land and were not allowed to leave it.

Domesday and the law

The Domesday Book, with unrivaled levels of detail on land-holders, was used in legal cases involving title, paving the way for precedents of title to become a cornerstone of English property law. Information such as the number of “hides” (the land needed to support one household) on each estate was used as late as 1193. The value of its detail waned over time, but the Domesday Book has stood as a foundational text of the English legal and political system for 900 years. ■

The Norman Conquest

William had become Duke of Normandy in 1035, aged just 8 years. In 1066, he crossed the English Channel to claim the crown, which he believed the Anglo-Saxon King Edward the Confessor had promised to him. He defeated Edward's successor, King Harold, at the Battle of Hastings, earning the name of William the Conqueror.

William brought an army of around 7,000 knights and men-at-arms. After defeating Harold, he needed to control the English population of more than 2 million people, to quash a series of revolts, and to ward off the threat of invasion by the Danes. So he rewarded his Norman followers with English land, much of it taken from Anglo-Saxon nobles. By the 1080s, the native land-holding aristocracy had been decimated. The Domesday Book documented that revolution in land-holding.



King Harold is said to have been killed by an arrow in the eye at the Battle of Hastings, shown in this scene from the Bayeux Tapestry.